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BEYOND FRAGMENTATION: A REASSESSMENT OF KHUBILAI KHAN'S "GRAND UNIFICATION PLAN" AND THE GOLDEN HORDE

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Abstract

This article reexamines the nature of political unity within the Mongol Empire following the succession crises and fragmentation of the mid-thirteenth century. While conventional historiography has generally interpreted the emergence of the Yuan dynasty, the Golden Horde, the Ilkhanate, and the Chagatai Khanate as marking the disintegration of a unified empire, this study argues that important forms of political, military, administrative, and economic interconnectedness continued to survive among the constituent states of the Mongol world. Focusing particularly on relations between the Yuan dynasty and the Golden Horde, the article examines military cooperation, diplomatic relations, investiture practices, administrative institutions, long-distance trade networks, and cultural exchange during the thirteenth and fourteenth centuries.

Drawing upon Persian, Chinese, Armenian, Russian, and European historical sources, the study engages with Sugiyama Masaaki's concept of Khubilai Khan's "Grand Unification Plan," which interprets the Mongol Empire as an integrated Eurasian imperial system sustained through military organization, administrative coordination, and transcontinental commerce. The article argues that, despite increasing regional autonomy, the constituent polities of the Mongol Empire continued for a considerable period to function within a broader confederative framework centered upon the authority of the Great Khan and the Yuan imperial court.

Keywords: *Mongol Empire, Khubilai Khan, Golden Horde, Yuan dynasty, Pax Mongolica, Sugiyama Masaaki, imperial governance, Eurasian interconnectedness*

Introduction

The Mongol Empire occupies a singular place in world history as the largest contiguous land empire ever created and as a political order that connected the civilizations of East and West across Eurasia. During the thirteenth and fourteenth centuries, the Mongols established an imperial system that incorporated nomadic and sedentary societies within a single political framework, facilitating unprecedented movements of peoples, goods, technologies, and ideas. The emergence of this vast

empire transformed the political, economic, and cultural structure of Eurasia and gave rise to what modern scholars commonly describe as the *Pax Mongolica*.

Despite broad agreement regarding the historical significance of the Mongol Empire, scholars remain divided concerning the nature of its internal political structure following the succession crises of the mid-thirteenth century. Conventional scholarship has generally interpreted the conflicts following the reigns of Ögedei Khan (r. 1229–1241), and Möngke Khan (r. 1251–1259)—particularly the struggle between Khubilai Khan (r. 1260–1294) and Ariq Böke (r. 1260–1264)—as marking the fragmentation of the empire into separate and increasingly autonomous khanates. According to this interpretation, the Yuan dynasty, the Golden Horde, the Ilkhanate, and the Chagatai Khanate gradually evolved into independent political entities that retained only nominal connections with the imperial center.

At the same time, other scholars have argued that the successor states of the Mongol Empire continued to preserve important forms of political, economic, and institutional interconnectedness long after the decline of centralized imperial authority. From this perspective, the empire did not simply disintegrate into isolated khanates, but instead functioned for a considerable period as a broader confederative system linked through dynastic legitimacy, diplomatic relations, commercial integration, military cooperation, and shared administrative practices.

Within this historiographical context, the Japanese scholar Sugiyama Masaaki proposed the concept of Khubilai Khan's "Grand Unification Plan," arguing that the Mongol Empire under the Yuan dynasty pursued the deliberate integration of Eurasia through military organization, administrative coordination, and transcontinental commerce.

Although Sugiyama's interpretation offers an important framework for reconsidering the nature of Mongol imperial governance, relatively little attention has been devoted to examining how this system operated in practice within the empire's western domains.

This article examines the relationship between the Yuan dynasty and the Golden Horde in order to evaluate the practical implementation of Khubilai Khan's "Grand Unification Plan." Drawing upon Persian, Chinese, Armenian, Russian, and European sources, it argues that although the constituent states of the Mongol Empire increasingly exercised political autonomy, they nevertheless remained connected through systems of military cooperation, diplomatic recognition, administrative institutions, commercial exchange, and imperial legitimacy centered upon the authority of the Great Khan. The Golden Horde, in particular, played a crucial role in sustaining the political and economic integration of the Mongol world by linking the eastern and western regions of Eurasia through trade, diplomacy, and imperial administration.

Rather than viewing the post-thirteenth-century Mongol Empire solely through the framework of fragmentation and decline, this study suggests that the empire continued to function for a considerable period as an interconnected imperial system. In this sense, Khubilai Khan's "Grand Unification Plan" may be understood not merely as an ideological vision, but as a practical model of governance that shaped relations among the constituent states of the Mongol Empire until the weakening of Yuan authority and the final collapse of Mongol imperial unity in the fourteenth century.

1. Historiography and the Question of Mongol Imperial Unity

1.1. Fragmentation and Political Autonomy

To understand this issue, it is first necessary to examine the major scholarly interpretations concerning the political fragmentation of the Mongol Empire. Following the death of Ögedei Khan, disputes over succession resulted in the temporary regency of his widow Töregene Khatun (regent 1241–1246). Subsequently, after the death of Güyük Khan (r. 1246–1248), the earlier understanding that the throne would remain within Ögedei's lineage was abandoned, and Möngke Khan of the Toluid line was elevated to the position of Great Khan. These developments significantly weakened the unity of the

imperial family and intensified political divisions among the descendants of Jochi (1181-1225), Tolui (1191-1232), Ögedei, and Chagatai (r. 1127 – 1242).

According to Rashid al-Din's *Jāmi' al-Tawārīkh*, these tensions became increasingly visible during the 1251 kurultai convened for the enthronement of Möngke Khan, when princes of the Chagataid and Ögedeid lines traveling to attend the assembly were discovered carrying weapons, resulting in the execution of numerous individuals. Thereafter, particularly following the struggle for supreme authority between Khubilai Khan and Ariq Böke, many scholars contend that the constituent uluses of the Mongol Empire gradually moved toward political autonomy and increasing regional independence.

For example, the German scholar Paul Ratchnevsky writes:

“The frontiers of the individual ulus were not clearly demarcated; even during Chinggis lifetime this led to quarrels between his sons and to aspirations towards independence. These differences became obvious at the siege of Urgench when, because this area was designated as his fief, Jochi sought to protect the town and the populace of Khorasan from destruction; Juzjani even asserts that Jochi intended to ally himself with the Muslims and found an independent state. Despite the measures introduced by Chinggis Khan (r. 1206 – 1227) the feudal system did hold dangers for the cohesion of the empire. While Chinggis was alive it was possible to keep the centrifugal forces within limits. After his death those forces constantly received fresh stimulation and this eventually led to the break up of the empire into four independent khanates.”¹

Similarly, the American scholar Morris Rossabi observes:

“Similarly, he was compelled to abandon his desire for rule over all the Mongol domains. The Golden Horde in Russia had pursued an independent policy long before Khubilai's accession as the Great Khan. The hostile Chagatai Khanate in Central Asia sought to topple Khubilai. The Ilkhans of Persia were the only Mongol group that remained loyal to the Great Khan, but, since communications between Persia and Khubilai's capital in Ta-tu were poor, the Ilkhans were autonomous.”²

The Russian-German historian Michael Pravdin similarly argues in *Genghis Khan and His Legacy* that the transfer of the imperial capital from Karakorum to Peking shifted the center of gravity of the Mongol Empire eastward. Although Khubilai Khan sought to unite political authority with what he regarded as the principal center of civilization, Pravdin maintains that “the differences that arose between the western Khanates could not be subordinated to the interests of a united empire with its capital in China.” He further writes:

“There was a rift in the mighty empire. The thought of a Mongolian unity bridging all opposition had lost its power... the three parts of the empire had to live their own lives, to conduct their own wars, and had therefore descended to the level of ordinary great powers. They were compelled to study the arts of policy, to cultivate alliances, to reckon with the peculiarities of conquered populations. Henceforward each of the three great Mongolian khanates had a history of its own.”³

According to *History of Mongolia*, vol. 2, after Öljeitü Khan (r. 1295–1304) ascended the throne of the Ilkhanate, the Chagatai Khanate and other constituent polities of the Mongol Empire formally acknowledged the authority of the Yuan emperor and expressed their submission. Likewise, the princes and nobles of the Golden Horde and the Ilkhanate recognized the sovereignty of the Yuan court, thereby

¹ Paul Ratchnevsky, *Genghis Khan: His Life and Legacy*, ed. Thomas Nivison Haining (Blackwell, 1999), 176–77.

² Morris Rossabi, *Khubilai Khan: His Life and Times* (University of California Press, 1992), 230–31.

³ Michael Pravdin, *The Mongol Empire: Its Rise and Legacy* (Routledge, 2017), 368, <https://doi.org/10.4324/9781315133201>.

demonstrating that the institution of the Great Khan continued to retain symbolic and political significance across the wider Mongol world.

Although these developments temporarily eased the political crisis during the reign of Öljeitü Khan, they did not restore the durable unity of the Mongol Empire. In practice, the Chagatai Khanate, the Ilkhanate, the Golden Horde, and the Yuan dynasty had each evolved into de facto independent political entities, exercising considerable autonomy in both internal administration and foreign affairs.⁴

1.2. *Confederative Interpretations and Continued Imperial Cohesion*

Although internal conflicts among the Golden Lineage weakened the overall governing capacity of the Mongol Empire, a number of scholars have argued that the Golden Horde, the Yuan dynasty, the Chagatai Khanate, and the Ilkhanate continued to function within a broader confederative imperial system. According to this interpretation, these constituent polities maintained political, diplomatic, and economic relations with one another and continued, at least formally, to recognize the authority of the Yuan court and the institution of the Great Khan until the final collapse of Mongol rule in China in 1368.

For example, the Japanese scholar Okada Hidehiro writes:

“Half a century after Chinggis Khan established the Mongol Empire—that is, by the mid-thirteenth century—the empire had divided into four great khanates ruled by his grandsons. ... However, this did not constitute the disintegration of the Mongol Empire; rather, it became a union of states, each possessing its own autonomous authority.”⁵

One of the founders of Eurasianism, the Russian-American historian G. V. Vernadsky, argues that the Mongol khans ruling the constituent states of the empire maintained relations of allegiance to the Great Khan over an extended period. According to Vernadsky, this relationship endured until the collapse of unified Mongol rule in China in 1368, thereby preserving a degree of institutional unity within the wider Mongol imperial system.⁶

Similarly, the Japanese scholar Miyawaki Junko observes that although the Yuan dynasty and the Golden Horde had effectively emerged as separate political entities during the reign of Khubilai Khan, the successor states of the Mongol Empire nevertheless continued to maintain mutual diplomatic and political relations in order to safeguard their collective security and strategic interests.

Although information concerning this issue remains relatively limited in both Chinese and Persian historical sources, a close examination of the available evidence suggests that the constituent states of the Mongol Empire exercised a considerable degree of political autonomy in practice. Nevertheless, in order to secure political legitimacy and obtain economic support from the Great Khan, these polities continued for a substantial period to recognize the authority of the imperial court based in Khanbaliq.⁷

Drawing upon Armenian and Persian sources, Dr. D. Bayarsaikhan, in her studies on the history of the Ilkhanate, demonstrates that from the reign of Hülegü Khan (r. 1256–1265) to that of Ghazan

⁴ L. Jamsran, *Монголын Түүх [History of Mongolia]* (Ulaanbaatar, 2003), 2:203.

⁵ Hidehiro Okada, *The Rise and Fall of the Mongol Empire* (Chikuma Shobō, 2001); see also Т. Мөнхцэнэг, *XIII-XIV зууны үеийн Монгол Японы харилцаа [Mongol-Japanese Relations in the 13th–14th Centuries]* (Ulaanbaatar, 2004), 41.

⁶ G. V. Vernadsky, *Монголчууд Ба Орос Орон [The Mongols and Russia]*, trans. D. Bazarsad (Ulaanbaatar, 2008), 21.

⁷ Junko Miyawaki, “Орсын Цар Алтан Ордыг залгамжилсан нь [The Russian Tsar as Successor to the Golden Horde],” in *Монголын түүхэн сурвалж бичгийн цуврал-26 /Богд Чингис хааны байлдааны бичиг [Series of Mongolian Historical Source Documents no. 26: The Military Records of Chinggis Khan]*, vol. 26, ed. Altanochir, trans. T. Munkhtsetseg (Ulaanbaatar, 2006), 82.

Khan (r. 1295–1304), the Ilkhanid rulers received formal investiture from the Great Khan. Although these rulers were initially proclaimed as khans within the Ilkhanate, they subsequently dispatched requests for confirmation to the imperial court, and only after receiving formal approval from the Great Khan was a second enthronement ceremony conducted. Bayarsaikhan further notes that royal women were at times sent from the Yuan dynasty to the Ilkhanate, reflecting the continued dynastic and political connections maintained within the Mongol imperial world.

From a synthesis of the views outlined above, it becomes evident that scholarly interpretations remain divided. While many historians emphasize the growing political autonomy of the constituent states and regard them as de facto independent polities, others maintain that important forms of institutional, dynastic, and diplomatic interconnectedness continued to survive within the broader framework of the Mongol imperial system.

2. Khubilai Khan's "Grand Unification Plan"

The question of whether the Mongol Empire retained meaningful political unity after the mid-thirteenth century has been reconsidered by the Japanese scholar Sugiyama Masaaki in his work *The Rise and Fall of the Mongol Empire*. Sugiyama proposes the concept of a "Grand Unification Plan," arguing that the Mongol Empire under Khubilai Khan pursued the deliberate integration of Eurasia through military organization, administrative coordination, and long-distance commerce. Rather than viewing the post-imperial Mongol world solely through the framework of fragmentation, Sugiyama suggests that the Yuan court continued to exercise a broader integrative function across the constituent polities of the empire. This interpretation provides an important framework for examining relations between the Yuan dynasty and the Golden Horde.

Sugiyama further argues that Khubilai Khan may be regarded as a second founder of the Mongol Empire, whose historical role paralleled that of his grandfather Chinggis Khan. Whereas the Persian historian Juvayni famously described Chinggis Khan as "the conqueror of the world," Sugiyama contends that Khubilai Khan may more appropriately be understood as a "reorganizer of the world." Although such a designation does not appear in surviving Eastern or Western historical sources, Sugiyama employs this characterization to emphasize Khubilai's efforts to restructure and stabilize the Mongol imperial order following the succession crises and political conflicts of the mid-thirteenth century.

According to Sugiyama, Khubilai Khan and his advisers envisioned the creation of a new imperial order grounded in three interrelated principles.⁸ First, the military foundations of Mongol rule were to be systematized through the organization of a multiethnic imperial army centered upon Mongol cavalry power. Second, the empire required administrative institutions and a stable fiscal base capable of exercising both direct and indirect control across its vast and multilayered territories. Central to this objective was the consolidation of North China, which represented the greatest concentration of economic wealth and productive capacity in Eurasia at the time. Third, this economic foundation was to support a transcontinental system of commercial exchange operating under the political authority of the Yuan court, otherwise "Khubilai's Administration", enabling the large-scale movement of goods, people, and resources across Eurasia. In this way, the traditional territorial divisions of the Mongol appanage system would be transcended through a broader framework of imperial integration.

Taken together, Sugiyama's "Grand Unification Plan" presents the Mongol Empire not merely as a collection of increasingly autonomous khanates, but as an interconnected imperial system sustained through military coordination, administrative structures, and economic exchange. The following

⁸ Sugiyama Masaaki, *Монголын эзэнт гүрний мандал буурал [The Rise and Fall of the Mongol Empire]*, trans. Ts. Tserendorj (Ulaanbaatar, 2015), 183. Originally published in Japanese as *モンゴル帝国の興亡*, 2 vols. (Tokyo: Kodansha, 1996).

sections examine the extent to which this model may be observed in practice through the political, military, and economic relations between the Yuan dynasty and the Golden Horde.

3. The Golden Horde and the Integration of the Mongol Empire

The practical implementation of Khubilai Khan's "Grand Unification Plan" may be observed particularly clearly in the relationship between the Yuan dynasty and the Golden Horde. Established by Batu Khan (r.1227-1255) upon the foundations laid by Jochi, the eldest son of Chinggis Khan, the Golden Horde occupied a crucial position within the wider Mongol imperial system, linking the western regions of Eurasia with the political center of the empire in China. Although the Golden Horde increasingly exercised political autonomy in regional affairs, evidence suggests that it nevertheless remained connected to the Yuan court through military cooperation, diplomatic relations, economic exchange, and shared imperial institutions.

3.1. Military and Political Integration

During the second half of the thirteenth century, contingents of Russian troops participated in Khubilai Khan's campaigns against Southern China.⁹ Chinese historical sources repeatedly record that, alongside Russian forces, the military structure of the Yuan dynasty incorporated units composed of Tanguts, Central Asian Sart soldiers, Asu (Alans), Kipchaks, and other non-Chinese groups.¹⁰ The composition of the Yuan army thus reflected the broader multiethnic character of the Mongol imperial system.

Additional evidence for the presence of foreign military and migrant communities within Yuan territory is provided by John of Montecorvino, the envoy dispatched by Pope Nicholas IV in 1289. After traveling through India and eventually arriving in Khanbaliq during the reign of Temür Khan, Montecorvino reported that he translated Christian liturgical texts into Mongolian, constructed a church, and baptized approximately 6,000 individuals. Significantly, he observed that the majority of these converts were not Chinese, but rather Alans, Turks, Russians, and Mongols. His account demonstrates the extent to which peoples from across the Mongol world had become integrated into the social and military environment of the Yuan dynasty.

The incorporation of such foreign populations into Yuan military structures appears closely connected to relations between the imperial center and the constituent states of the empire. Evidence suggests that the khans of the Golden Horde, as part of their recognition of Yuan authority, supplied military personnel, slaves, and captured Russians to the Yuan court. Given the Yuan dynasty's large population, recurring rebellions, and chronic internal instability, the strengthening of the imperial guard through the deployment of foreign troops represented both a practical military necessity and a deliberate political strategy.¹¹

According to the *History of the Yuan Dynasty*, during the reign of Tugh Temür (r. 1329–1332), approximately 10,000 Russians were assembled, supplied with 100 *qin* of grain, and settled under the supervision of the imperial guard unit known as the *Shuangzun Huwei*. Although many had originally arrived for other purposes, they were subsequently employed in agricultural production in order to reduce pressure on the local economy. Chinese official histories further indicate that these settlers became permanent residents and remained in China until at least 1339, with little opportunity to return to their homeland. Such evidence suggests that relations between the Yuan dynasty and the Golden

⁹ Vernadsky, *Монголчууд Ба Орос Орон* [*The Mongols and Russia*], 20.

¹⁰ Tōru Saguchi, *The Mongol Empire and the West*, trans. Buyandelger (Inner Mongolia Publishing House, 2006), 170–71. Originally published in Japanese as *モンゴル帝国と西洋* (Tokyo: Heibonsha, 1970).

¹¹ Masaaki, *Монголын эзэнт гүрний мандал буурал* [*The Rise and Fall of the Mongol Empire*], 20.

Horde extended beyond symbolic diplomacy and involved tangible forms of military and administrative cooperation.

Khubilai Khan's reliance upon foreign military forces may also be understood within the broader political conditions of his reign. Faced with repeated uprisings and internal unrest, the Yuan court appears to have viewed troops lacking local affiliations as particularly effective in suppressing rebellion. The organization of a multiethnic imperial army was therefore not merely incidental, but formed part of a wider strategy of imperial integration consistent with Sugiyama's conception of the "Grand Unification Plan."

Military integration was accompanied by continued political coordination among the constituent states of the Mongol Empire. During the reign of Berke Khan (r. 1257 – 1266), relations between the Golden Horde and the Ilkhanate deteriorated into open warfare,¹² producing a situation in which Mongol armies fought one another in the western regions of Eurasia. These conflicts threatened the broader unity of the empire and complicated the political balance of West Asia and Europe. According to the sources, Khubilai Khan strongly criticized these developments and intervened diplomatically in an effort to reconcile the opposing parties and restore relations between them.

The success of these efforts was closely connected to the prestige and authority that Khubilai Khan continued to exercise as Great Khan. After the death of Berke Khan, his successor Möngke Temür (r. 1266–1280) maintained peace with the Ilkhanate for a period under pressure and persuasion from Khubilai Khan, while simultaneously preserving relations with the Mamluk Sultanate. These developments suggest that, despite increasing regional autonomy, the constituent polities of the Mongol Empire continued to recognize the political authority and diplomatic influence of the Yuan court. Significantly, such patterns of political coordination did not end with the reign of Khubilai Khan, but persisted into the later Yuan period.

3.2. Administrative and Economic Interconnectedness

From the early fourteenth century onward, internal political instability within the Yuan dynasty—characterized by frequent imperial succession and weakening centralized authority—began to affect relations between the Yuan court and the constituent states of the Mongol Empire. During this period, the Ilkhan Öljeitü Khan engaged in conflict with Tokhta Khan (1256 – 1312) of the Golden Horde, while Duwa (r. 1282 – 1307) of the Chagatai Khanate launched campaigns against the territories of his former ally Chapar. These developments reflected the growing political tensions that increasingly challenged the cohesion of the wider imperial system.

Nevertheless, evidence suggests that the political authority of the Yuan court and the institutional framework of the empire continued to retain significance across Eurasia. Around 1313–1314, following an unsuccessful campaign against the Yuan emperor Ayurbarwada Buyantu Khan (1285 – 1320), Esen Buqa (r. 1310 – 1318) of the Chagatai Khanate attempted to draw Özbeg Khan (1282 – 1341) of the Golden Horde into an anti-Yuan alliance by falsely claiming that the Yuan emperor intended to replace him with another successor to Tokhta Khan. However, after investigating the matter, Özbeg Khan and his official Qutlugh Temür determined that the Yuan court had undertaken no hostile actions against the Golden Horde. Consequently, Özbeg declined to support Esen Buqa, who was once again defeated by Yuan forces.

At the same time, Özbeg Khan continued established patterns of political and economic interaction with the Yuan court. He received formal recognition from the Yuan emperor in the form of a third-rank official title and the right to collect revenues from Pingyang, Qinzhou, and Yongzhou. In return, he expressed his gratitude through tribute missions that included Russian captives among their offerings. After his death, his successor Jani Beg (r. 1342 – 1357) likewise sought formal confirmation

¹² Saguchi, *The Mongol Empire and the West*, 134.

of his rule from the Yuan court and continued to receive revenues from the same Chinese provinces. These practices indicate that relations between the Yuan dynasty and the Golden Horde extended beyond symbolic diplomacy and involved concrete administrative and economic arrangements. Such ties persisted until the outbreak of the Red Turban Rebellion in 1351, which effectively brought relations between the two polities to an end.¹³

From an administrative perspective, evidence of continued imperial integration may also be observed in the institution of the *darughachi*, the military-civil official responsible for administering conquered territories throughout the Mongol Empire. Regardless of region, *darughachi* performed broadly similar functions, including the supervision of censuses, conscription, taxation, tribute collection, and local administration. The widespread implementation of this institution suggests the existence of a common administrative framework extending across the constituent states of the empire.

Taken together, the multiethnic military structures discussed above and the empire-wide operation of the *darughachi* system may be interpreted as evidence for the implementation of the first and second components of Khubilai Khan's "Grand Unification Plan." The Mongols sought not only to organize a vast multiethnic military force centered upon cavalry power, but also to establish administrative institutions and a financial base capable of exercising both direct and indirect control across the empire's extensive territories.

Although conflicts and misunderstandings periodically emerged among the constituent states, they did not entirely abandon the broader framework of imperial relations. In many instances, disputes were resolved through negotiation and diplomatic reconciliation. An important illustration of this may be found in a letter sent by Öljeitü Khan to Philip IV of France in 1305, in which the Ilkhan emphasized that the descendants of Chinggis Khan had restored unity among themselves after earlier conflicts and had reopened the relay routes connecting the lands "from the rising sun to the western seas." He further declared that the Mongol rulers had agreed to act collectively against any threat directed toward one of their realms.¹⁴

The maintenance of these political relationships was closely connected to the protection of long-distance trade and communication networks. Through state policy, Khubilai Khan placed the relay system (*yam*) and the Silk Road under imperial protection, enabling merchants to travel and conduct commerce safely across the vast territory stretching from the Yuan capital to the Mediterranean. This policy laid the foundation for the emergence of a transcontinental commercial system operating under Mongol political authority.

Within this system, the Golden Horde occupied a particularly important strategic position on the western frontier of the Mongol Empire. Acting as an intermediary between East and West, it facilitated the uninterrupted circulation of goods, merchants, and information across Eurasia. Camel caravans traveled continuously between the Yuan capital of Dadu and the Golden Horde capital of Sarai, a journey requiring approximately two hundred days. In addition, merchants received loans and financial support from the authorities, reflecting the deliberate economic policies pursued by Mongol rulers to sustain long-distance trade.

The Golden Horde also undertook measures to facilitate westward commercial exchange by establishing crossings along the Don and Volga rivers, thereby enabling merchants from different regions to engage in direct trade. Cities situated along the Silk Road within Golden Horde territory developed into major commercial centers supplying luxury goods from the East to European markets.

¹³ Roman Pochekaev, *Khany Zolotoy Ordý [Khans of the Golden Horde]* (St. Petersburg, 2010), 186.

¹⁴ T. Tömörkhüleg, ed. and trans., *Франц болон бусад гадаад хэлээрх Монголын түүхийн холбогдолтой баримт бичгийн эмхэтгэл [A Collection of Documents on Mongolian History in French and Other Foreign Languages]* (Ulaanbaatar, 2006), 9–11.

Their prosperity became closely tied to the wider system of Eurasian exchange fostered under Mongol rule.

The Japanese scholar Saguchi Tōru notes that international trade linking the Volga region, the Black Sea, and Khwarezmia became concentrated in the Golden Horde capital of Sarai, which by the early fourteenth century had developed into a major center of craftsmanship and global commerce. According to Saguchi, the prosperity of Sarai emerged within the broader framework of the Pax Mongolica and contributed to the development of a monetized economy connected to regions surrounding the Caspian Sea.

The khans of the Golden Horde also granted commercial privileges to merchants from Venice and Genoa, permitting them to establish trading colonies along the Crimean coast of the Black Sea. As a result, commercial centers such as Kaffa and Tana flourished as important hubs linking Europe with the states of the East.¹⁵ The commercial activities of the Golden Horde thus extended far beyond the Black Sea and Volga regions, contributing to the broader integration of Europe, Russia, the Near East, and China within a shared economic system.

Merchants seeking luxury goods—particularly silk—did not necessarily travel directly to China, as such commodities could often be obtained within the territory of the Golden Horde itself. Continuous connections between the Golden Horde, Karakorum, and China transformed the western Mongol territories into intermediary commercial centers supplying Eastern products to European markets. At the same time, direct trade routes connected the Don River basin with Hangzhou in southern China. The Genoese harbor of Tana on the Sea of Azov became one of the principal points of departure for commerce with the East.

This interconnected commercial world is vividly reflected in the account of the Florentine merchant Francesco Balducci Pegolotti in his *La pratica della mercatura* (c. 1340). Describing the route from Tana to Cathay, Pegolotti emphasized that merchants could travel safely across Mongol territory both day and night, noting that “everywhere, in fact, a Pax Tatarica prevailed.” His account illustrates the degree to which Mongol political authority facilitated the security and integration of Eurasian trade networks during the fourteenth century. To specify, he wrote:

“The road from Tana to the city of Sarai may appear somewhat less reliable than other routes leading to Cathay. However, along this stretch of the journey, a group of about sixty men may travel as safely as if they were in their own country. As for the route from Tana to Cathay, it is entirely safe both day and night. Everywhere along the way prevails the order established by the Tatars, known as the Pax Tatarica.”¹⁶

3.3. Cultural Exchange and the Pax Mongolica

Under the patronage and protection of the Mongol rulers, the expansion of long-distance commerce facilitated an unprecedented transmission of cultural, technological, and scientific knowledge between East and West. The security provided by the Pax Mongolica and the maintenance of imperial trade and communication networks enabled merchants, envoys, missionaries, craftsmen, and scholars to travel across Eurasia with a degree of mobility previously unknown in medieval history. As a result, regions that had once remained politically and culturally distant entered into far closer contact, contributing significantly to broader processes of global historical development.

¹⁵ N. Ishjamts et al., *Монголын эзэнт гүрний гадаад харилцаа (XIII-XIV) [Foreign Relations of the Mongol Empire (13th–14th Centuries)]* (Ulaanbaatar, 1995), 134.

¹⁶ Michael Prawdin, *Чингис хаан, түүний өв [Genghis Khan and His life and Legacy]*, trans. D. Moonontsagaan (Ulaanbaatar, 2005), 239.

One of the clearest manifestations of this exchange may be observed in the circulation of luxury goods, technologies, and artistic traditions across the Mongol world. In Europe, the growing demand for Chinese silk stimulated not only increased consumption but also efforts to imitate Eastern textile production and develop local substitutes. At the same time, important innovations originating in East Asia, including printing technology, porcelain production, gunpowder, coal usage, and the abacus, gradually became known in the West through the commercial and diplomatic networks maintained under Mongol rule. Conversely, Western and Near Eastern craftsmanship also flourished during this period. Italian goldsmithing and Venetian glassware became especially renowned, while artistic and decorative techniques from Byzantium and Persia, including enamelwork and glass inlays, spread widely across Eurasia and were incorporated into the architectural decoration of palaces, religious institutions, and elite urban spaces.

The movement of goods across Eurasia was therefore accompanied by the transmission of artistic styles, technical knowledge, religious ideas, and forms of material culture. Numerous artifacts reflecting these exchanges have survived and continue to be recovered through archaeological excavations conducted across the former territories of the Mongol Empire.¹⁷ Such evidence demonstrates that the Pax Mongolica was not solely an economic phenomenon, but also a broader process of cultural interaction and civilizational exchange.

By bringing the previously distant and often unfamiliar worlds of East and West into sustained political, economic, commercial, cultural, and religious contact, the Mongols succeeded in integrating nomadic and sedentary civilizations within a shared historical framework. In this respect, the Mongol Empire played a transformative role in the development of Eurasian interconnectedness and made a distinctive contribution to the broader history of human civilization.¹⁸

4. The Limits of Imperial Unity

The developments outlined above may be understood as reflecting the practical realization of the third objective of Khubilai Khan's "Grand Unification Plan"—namely, the creation of a transcontinental system of exchange operating under the political authority of the Yuan court and supported by the economic wealth and productive capacity of Eurasia. The movement of peoples, goods, information, and diplomatic missions increasingly transcended the traditional territorial divisions of the Mongol appanage system, contributing to the formation of a broader imperial framework that linked the constituent polities of the Mongol world. In this respect, Sugiyama Masaaki's interpretation of the Mongol Empire as an interconnected imperial order appears to correspond closely with the historical evidence examined above.

Adhering to the political principles established by their imperial predecessors, the rulers of the Mongol Empire continued for a considerable period to preserve relations with one another and maintain elements of broader imperial cohesion. Although the constituent states frequently pursued their own regional interests and did not coordinate all aspects of policy, they nevertheless remained connected to the imperial center in matters of diplomacy, military affairs, commerce, and dynastic legitimacy. Conflicts and rivalries certainly emerged among the successor states, yet the ruling elites repeatedly attempted to resolve such disputes within a shared political framework rooted in the authority of the Great Khan and the legacy of Chinggisid rule.

¹⁷ In March 2026, an exhibition entitled "*Descendants of Chinggis Khan: Russians and the Wider World*" was opened at the Moscow Kremlin Museums to commemorate the institution's 220th anniversary. This exhibition represents the first official exhibition in the Russian Federation to be named after Chinggis Khan.

More than 150 rare and valuable artifacts related to the history of the Mongol Empire and the Golden Horde are displayed, drawn from the collections of over ten institutions, including the Moscow Kremlin Museums, the State Hermitage Museum, and the State Historical Museum.

¹⁸ J. Boldbaatar, *Монголчууд дэлхий дахины түүхнээ* [*The Mongols in World History*] (Ulaanbaatar, 2007).

Evidence that contemporaries themselves continued to perceive the Mongol world as a connected political and commercial sphere may also be found in the famous Catalan Atlas produced in 1375 by the Majorcan cartographer Abraham Cresques and now preserved in the Bibliothèque nationale de France in Paris. The map depicts not only the territories formerly governed by the Mongols, but also the routes, relay stations, commercial centers, and lines of communication linking the various regions of Eurasia. Such representations suggest that even outside observers understood the Mongol domains as forming part of a wider interconnected imperial space.

At the same time, however, the cohesion of this system remained dependent upon the stability and prestige of the Yuan imperial center. Internal struggles for succession within the Yuan dynasty, combined with recurring natural disasters, economic strain, and regional unrest, gradually weakened the political authority of the Great Khan. As centralized power declined, the constituent states increasingly lost the capacity to coordinate their policies and support one another within the broader imperial framework. The outbreak of the Red Turban Rebellion in the mid-fourteenth century further accelerated this process, ultimately contributing to the collapse of Yuan rule in 1368 and the dissolution of Mongol imperial unity.

Thus, while the Mongol Empire eventually fragmented into increasingly autonomous successor states, the evidence examined in this study suggests that fragmentation did not immediately result in complete political disintegration. Rather, the Yuan dynasty, the Golden Horde, the Ilkhanate, and the Chagatai Khanate continued for a significant period to function within a broader confederative system characterized by military cooperation, diplomatic interaction, administrative continuity, and economic interconnectedness. The limits of imperial unity therefore lay not in the absence of integrative structures, but in the gradual weakening of the political center upon which those structures depended.

Conclusion

In conclusion, the evidence examined in this study suggests that Khubilai Khan's "Grand Unification Plan" was not merely an ideological vision, but a practical model of imperial governance that shaped relations among the constituent states of the Mongol Empire during the thirteenth and fourteenth centuries. Although the successor polities of the empire increasingly exercised regional autonomy following the succession crises of the mid-thirteenth century, they nevertheless continued to maintain important forms of political, military, administrative, and economic interconnectedness centered upon the authority of the Great Khan and the Yuan imperial court.

The relationship between the Yuan dynasty and the Golden Horde demonstrates particularly clearly that the fragmentation of the Mongol Empire did not immediately result in complete political disintegration. Military cooperation, diplomatic mediation, investiture practices, administrative institutions, tribute relations, and long-distance commercial exchange continued to link the constituent states within a broader imperial framework. The evidence further suggests that the Mongol rulers consciously sought to preserve these connections in order to sustain political stability, secure trade routes, and maintain control over the vast territories of Eurasia.

At the same time, this study also demonstrates that the unity of the Mongol imperial system possessed important limitations. The cohesion of the empire depended heavily upon the authority and stability of the Yuan center, and as internal political struggles, economic difficulties, and natural disasters weakened the power of the Great Khan, the mechanisms sustaining imperial integration gradually deteriorated. By the mid-fourteenth century, the constituent states increasingly lost the capacity to coordinate their policies and support one another, ultimately leading to the collapse of Mongol imperial unity.

Nevertheless, the historical evidence indicates that the Mongol Empire continued for a considerable period to function as a broader confederative and interconnected imperial system even after the emergence of separate khanates. In this respect, Sugiyama Masaaki's interpretation provides an

important framework for reconsidering the nature of post-fragmentation Mongol governance. Rather than viewing the Yuan dynasty, the Golden Horde, the Ilkhanate, and the Chagatai Khanate solely as isolated successor states, they may more appropriately be understood as constituent parts of a wider Eurasian imperial order linked through shared political traditions, administrative institutions, and transcontinental networks of exchange. Through these connections, the Mongol Empire played a transformative role in shaping the political, economic, and cultural history of Eurasia.

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